

Appendix : A Comparative Explanation of Causal Inference Terminology in Medicine and End to End Autonomous Driving (AD) Models

Intervention

* Medicine: causal inference for treatment effects

Surgery, medication, therapeutic procedure

* AD Models: causal inference for action (task) selection

The intervention corresponds to the action (task) selected by the autonomous driving model. (acceleration, braking and stopping, right or left steering)

Confounding

* Medicine: Background differences distort treatment effect estimates

(severe patients receive aggressive therapy)

* AD Models:

Environmental factors influence both action (task) selection and outcomes

(On narrow roads, night time conditions combined with low- μ road surfaces increase both braking frequency and accident risk.)

Control Group: a set of observational instances used as a reference for causal comparison, typically consisting of units that did not receive (were intentionally controlled by withholding) the intervention under comparable conditions

* Medicine: Patients who did not receive the treatment

* AD Models

Unselected alternative actions (tasks) correspond to hypothetical scenarios—“what if it had not braked (hard braking)?” or “what if it had gone straight instead of turning (steering)?”

These represent counterfactual outcomes, i.e., unobserved results under alternative actions (tasks) in the same situation. (This description follows the conventional definition of a control group used in causal inference.)

In contrast, the control group in the context of autonomous driving should be understood as empirically observed instances in which different actions (tasks) were taken under similar, comparable conditions, providing real world reference data for causal comparison.

Simulation-based environments can approximate counterfactual outcomes by reconstructing the same scenario and altering actions (tasks); however, their validity depends on simulation fidelity and may be limited by discrepancies from real world dynamics (see the main paper).

In contrast, **Treatment Group**

* Medicine: Patients who actually received the treatment

* AD Models

The set of actions (tasks) the model actually selected

(executed a hard brake, turned right or left, stopped)

Covariates

* Medicine: Background factors influencing treatment choice and outcomes

(age, comorbidities, severity, lifestyle, family medical history)

* AD Models

Environmental and vehicle factors influencing action (task) choice and outcomes

(weather, night time, congestion, pedestrian density, ODD conditions, sensor state)

Propensity Score

* Medicine: Probability that a patient receives a treatment given covariates

* AD Models

Probability that the model selects a specific action (task) given the observed situation

It is implicitly encoded within the model's internal decision-making structure.

In other words, it is implicitly associated with the model's internal purpose hierarchy and can be formally approximated from the model policy or decision function.

A **covariate** is a baseline clinical factor that may influence treatment selection and/or patient outcomes. Among these, variables that causally affect both are **confounders** and must be adjusted for, as they open backdoor paths.

In the context of autonomous driving, the counterparts to **covariates** are baseline environmental and vehicle-state factors that may influence both the selection of intervention **tasks** (such as braking or steering) and accident risk.

Among these, factors that causally affect both function as **confounders**, as they open backdoor paths and must be statistically adjusted for.

A **propensity score** is the probability that a patient with given baseline **covariates** will receive a particular treatment.

1. More severe patients are more likely to receive aggressive treatments.
2. Younger patients are more likely to receive invasive therapies.
3. Older patients are more likely to receive conservative rather than surgical treatments.

In autonomous driving, a **propensity score** $PSe(x) = P(\text{intervention} \mid X = x)$ represents the probability that a vehicle will select a particular intervention action (task) given observed **covariates** such as weather, night time conditions, traffic congestion, pedestrian density, ODD constraints, and sensor state.

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Godspeed on your research and development

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